



// MAJOR PROJECT, FINAL REPORT

KICKERSHOE

EVERY SHOE HAS A STORY

Final Project Report

A shared universe of fictional shoe origin motion comics

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// SECTION 01

Introduction

This is the final report for KICKERSHOE, the Major Project completed across the 2025 to 2026 academic year for the MA Web Design and Content Planning programme at the University of Greenwich. The project began in October 2025 as a proposal for a non commercial platform about sneaker culture called Sick.Shoes. It ends, in September 2026, as a live, hand built website at kickershoe.com that tells the same underlying story (the culture and craft behind well known shoe designs) through a different form: a shared universe of fictional motion comic origin stories, told by invented animal characters, with four full issues published and a fifth invited from readers themselves.

The brief for this module (University of Greenwich, 2025) asks for a single compiled report of 10,000 to 15,000 words that gathers the themed sub-reports written across the year, that is, Concept, Research, Business, Cultural Context, Commodity, Delight, Firmness, Prototype, Implementation and Analysis, corrected and updated to describe the site as it now stands and the process behind it, and closing with a conclusion on the project's success and a reflection on what could have been done differently. One point should be stated plainly before going further. Several of these sub-reports were not written up as separate one thousand word documents at the time, in the informal, non assessed spirit the brief itself allows, since it states that the presentations and reports are not an end in themselves. The themed content still exists, however, in the record of the five crit presentations delivered across the year (University of Greenwich MA Web Design and Content Planning, 2026) and the decisions made around them, and this report reconstructs each phase properly from that record rather than skipping any of it.

The report follows the module's own analytical framework: the non Vitruvian principles of Business and Cultural Context, and the Vitruvian principles of Commodity, Firmness and Delight (University of Greenwich, 2025), framed by the Concept and Research work that opened the project and the Prototype, Implementation, Analysis and Completion work that closed it. Each section explains what was proposed at the relevant crit, what was actually built, and, where the two differ, why. The single largest of those differences, and the one this report tries hardest not to understate, concerns the project's own subject. What started as a magazine style platform about real sneaker culture became, during implementation, a fictional comic universe that only alludes to real sneaker culture. That is a bigger change than a rename or a simplified feature list, and it is treated here as the central story of the report rather than a footnote.

A short note on authorship and tools, expanded fully in Section 13. AI tools, principally Claude and Claude Code, were used throughout this project to support research, planning and a share of the final hand edited code, alongside more familiar tools (Figma, Lovable, ChatGPT, Adobe Firefly) for prototyping and image generation. This is declared consistently with the declaration carried through the crits from the Prototype stage onward, and is treated as a decision to be explained rather than hidden, in line with the module's own aim that students should be able to explain and justify their decisions during project development (University of Greenwich, 2025). The written analysis, argument and final wording of this report are the author's own.

// SECTION 02

Concept

The brief asks the Concept report to cover five things: a 140 character description, an elevator pitch, a longer account of the problem, a longer account of the value proposition, and the project's unique selling proposition, together with an optional manifesto (University of Greenwich, 2025). This work was carried out informally in Autumn 2025, ahead of the first dated crit, in line with the module's own Phase 1 structure. This section restates all five as they stood then and as they stand now, because the underlying concept survived almost completely intact even while its name and its content format both changed around it.

140 character description

At the concept stage: Sick.Shoes, a storytelling platform for people who see meaning in every stitch, scuff and colourway. Not a shop. A love letter.

Today: KICKERSHOE, a shared universe of fictional motion comics that turns a real shoe's most memorable design detail into a whole illustrated origin story.

The elevator pitch

KICKERSHOE is best described first as a beautiful, artistic concept before it is described as anything else. It is a publishing platform, not a shop and not a portfolio, built on the idea that a shoe's design can be told as a hand painted comic rather than a spec sheet. Each issue is a short motion comic that follows one invented animal character through the kind of setback, struggle or overlooked moment that (unofficially, unaffiliated, entirely made up) explains how a real, well known shoe silhouette came to exist. Issue 001 gives a mocked, injured mantis a football boot. Issue 002 gives an undersized boxing goat the F50. Issue 003 gives a stubborn elephant the Converse Originals. Issue 004 gives a swimmer a shoe built in memory of the goldfish that steadied him through a storm. The site's own About page describes these characters as animals living through a broken leg, a robbed shoe, or an underestimated moment (kickershoe.com/about), and it is true that each of the four issues so far follows a character overcoming hardship. This report treats that pattern as one recurring feature of the storytelling rather than a fixed rule the project must always follow, since the real appeal the concept is built around is the craft and illustration itself, not a single plot formula. None of the four issues exists in isolation. Today's antagonist is written to become tomorrow's collaborator, so the goat's rival in Issue 002 appears again in a later issue as the co-designer of the boot. In the project's own words, it is part comic anthology, part alternate history sneaker museum, and part shared universe that anyone can pitch a character into (kickershoe.com/about).

The problem this solves, or more precisely the gap it fills, is that sneaker media as a genre is almost entirely non fiction, built around three familiar moves: release calendar news, hype driven cop or drop verdicts, and interview style storytelling with athletes and designers (the specific outlets this is based on are named in the Research section below). All of it treats the shoe as a product to be reviewed. None of the major cognate outlets treat the shoe as a character with a life of its own, or as the subject of an artwork in its own right. That gap, rather than any complaint about the quality of the existing outlets, which is generally high, was the actual space the concept was built around from the start, and it

survived the format change intact. The original concept's description of people who see meaning in every stitch and the About page's description of starting from a silhouette's most iconic detail (a spring, a stud plate, a suture) and building an entire animal and an entire heartbreak to explain how it had to exist (kickershoe.com/about) are the same idea, expressed a year apart in two different forms.

The value proposition

For a reader, KICKERSHOE offers something no cognate sneaker outlet offers: a reason to care about a shoe's design details that has nothing to do with whether it can be afforded, resold, or worn to be seen in. The comic format, and the artwork behind it, does emotional work that spec sheet copy cannot. A spring loaded sole is more memorable as the twist inside an elephant's origin story than as a bullet point in a press release. For the project itself, the value proposition is creative and reputational rather than commercial. It is a public, citable body of finished, illustrated, narrative work that demonstrates the range of skills the MA is meant to develop, including content strategy, illustration direction, semantic front end engineering, accessibility, SEO and independent project management, all in one coherent artefact. This matches the portfolio piece outcome the module brief names explicitly (University of Greenwich, 2025).

Unique selling proposition

No other sneaker culture platform tells its stories as a fictional, illustrated, shared comic universe with recurring characters and hidden real world references. Every major cognate outlet identified in the Research section is non fiction and photography led. Every comparable comic platform identified there is fiction led but not about sneakers. KICKERSHOE's USP is occupying that specific space between the two: a comic universe whose entire premise is real shoe design history, told through invented folklore and original illustration rather than marketing copy.

Manifesto

The manifesto set at the concept stage, in the author's own words at the time, reads roughly as follows. Kickershoe is for people who cannot look at a pair of trainers without also wondering about the night they were worn or the scene they came from. It treats each shoe like a small exhibition, slowing things down so the reader can sit with the details. The comic universe is that same instinct taken one step further. Instead of asking a reader to imagine the story behind a real shoe's stitching, it writes that story for them, on the understanding that an invented story, told with enough craft and enough care in the illustration, does similar emotional work to a half remembered real one, and is far more achievable for one student to produce to a professional standard inside a twelve month project.

Give a girl the right shoes, and she can conquer the world.

Marilyn Monroe, quoted as an opening line in the author's Completion presentation (Eapen, 2026)

The name changes, and why they happened

The project has carried three names. It started at the concept stage as Sick.Shoes, a name chosen to signal a personal, storytelling platform rather than a retail site. Ahead of the Prototype crit it changed to Kickershoes. The main reason for this change was SEO, not taste. A name built around a period, as in sick.shoes, does not read cleanly as a single searchable brand term, and the word sick carries other,

unrelated meanings online that made the site harder to find and rank for the right searches. Tutors reviewing the project advised moving to a name that would perform better in search results, and Kickershoes, later shortened to the single word KICKERSHOE used at kickershoe.com, was chosen for exactly that reason: a plain, ownable, keyword bearing name that search engines and readers alike can find without confusion. The concept and the visual moodboard were unchanged at each point. These were naming and search decisions, not creative ones. Each rename is disclosed here for the same reason it was disclosed at the crit where it happened, since the module rewards being able to explain and justify decisions during project development (University of Greenwich, 2025), and a name that changes without comment reads as an oversight, while one that is named and explained each time reads as a project kept under proper editorial control.

// SECTION 03

Research

The brief asks for an analysis of the existing web landscape: cognate websites in the same niche or genre, and non cognate websites that serve a similar function in a different subject area, together with a competitor analysis covering popularity, business model, and what can be learned or improved on (University of Greenwich, 2025). Because KICKERSHOE sits at an unusual point between two fields, sneaker culture content and webcomic publishing, this section treats sneaker media as the cognate set and comic publishing platforms as the non cognate set. The first group shares KICKERSHOE's subject but not its form. The second shares its form but not its subject.

Cognate analysis: sneaker and streetwear media

Hypebeast began in 2005 as a solo sneaker blog run by Kevin Ma with no professional writing background, and has since grown into a full streetwear and lifestyle publisher reporting tens of millions of monthly page views, alongside a retail arm and a print magazine (Chaney, 2015; Hypebeast, 2026). Highsnobiety launched the same year as a similarly personal project from David Fischer and Jeff Carvalho, and now draws upward of nine million monthly visitors, with its own print magazine and a branded content studio (Highsnobiety, 2026; TechCrunch, 2018). Complex runs dedicated Sneakers and Style sections and produces two long running sneaker culture video and podcast series, Sneaker Shopping and Full Size Run, now combined into The Complex Sneakers Podcast, built around interviews with athletes and artists (Complex, 2026).

What all three share, and what sets them apart from KICKERSHOE, is that they are fundamentally news operations: fast turnaround release coverage, ranked cop or drop lists, sponsored content and access journalism, published at a volume (Hypebeast alone publishes around forty to fifty articles a day) that a single student project has no realistic way of matching, and little reason to try to match. Coveteur and GQ's sneaker coverage sit at the more luxury end of the same genre, more photography led and more editorial in tone, but still reviewing real product rather than telling invented stories about it. None of the five treats a shoe as a character. All five treat a shoe as a subject to be photographed, ranked or interviewed about. This gap, confirmed rather than assumed by this research, is what the Concept section's problem statement rests on.

The competitor lesson worth taking seriously is about production speed rather than content angle. Hypebeast's daily volume and Complex's continuous video and podcast output are only possible with a staff, and the SWOT analysis in Section 4 already names slow content production, correctly, as a structural weakness for a one person operation. A realistic response is not to compete on volume but to compete on the thing volume makes difficult, that is, the amount of craft and illustration in each piece, which a small archive of well made issues can sustain and a fast, high volume operation structurally cannot.

Non cognate analysis: webcomic and serialised fiction platforms

WEBTOON is the clearest non cognate comparator: a vertical scroll, mobile first comics platform launched in Korea in 2004 and in the United States in 2014, now reaching roughly fifteen million readers a day worldwide and reporting international revenue of 3.5 billion dollars in 2023 (TaleAtelier,

2026). Two of its choices directly informed KICKERSHOE's own Commodity decisions in Section 6: publishing in small, complete instalments rather than a continuous stream, and an open submission tier called Canvas that lets any creator publish into the platform's shared audience, which is the direct ancestor of KICKERSHOE's own invitation for readers to pitch a character. WEBTOON differs from KICKERSHOE in subject matter, since romance, fantasy and slice of life stories dominate its charts rather than product culture history, and in infrastructure, since it is a hosted platform with its own content system, discovery algorithm and payment tools, none of which a small, hand built static site needs to copy at this scale.

The reason a comic can be treated as a serious storytelling medium, rather than a lightweight add on to a sneaker blog, comes from Scott McCloud's *Understanding Comics*, whose central argument is that the space between panels, which he calls closure, is where a reader does real narrative work, and that a panel divides time and space more through its content than through its border (McCloud, 1994). This is close to the mechanism behind KICKERSHOE's ten panel, scroll triggered issue pages. Each panel reveals as the reader scrolls, with its caption typed in word by word, so the reader's own pace becomes part of the comic's pacing, a modest but direct translation of McCloud's panel and gutter theory into a CSS and JavaScript scroll animation pattern (see Section 8, Firmness).

Comparative summary

The table below sets the five cognate and non cognate comparators discussed above against KICKERSHOE, on the points that matter most for a solo, non commercial project: content form, subject matter, publishing rhythm and monetisation. It is a small, readable table rather than an exhaustive feature list, in line with the brief's own suggestion that a comparative table may help without needing to be complete (University of Greenwich, 2025).

Site	Form	Subject	Model
Hypebeast	News articles, 40 to 50 a day	Streetwear, sneakers, lifestyle	Ads, e-commerce, print
Highsnobiety	News plus branded content	Streetwear, sneakers, fashion	Ads, branded content, print
Complex	Articles, video, podcast	Sneakers, style, pop culture	Ads, sponsorship
WEBTOON	Vertical scroll serial comics	Romance, fantasy, slice of life	Freemium, ads, licensing
KICKERSHOE	Vertical scroll reveal motion comics, 4 issues	Fictional sneaker origin folklore	Non commercial, newsletter only

Reading across the row, KICKERSHOE is the only entry that combines comic form with sneaker culture subject matter, and the only one with no advertising, sponsorship or e-commerce layer at all, which is a direct expression of the Business case set out in Section 4.

What the research changed

- Confirmed that no direct competitor occupies the sneaker comic space, which reduced the risk of the format change rather than making it a leap of faith.

- Set a realistic publishing pace (a small number of well made issues rather than a daily news feed), which shaped the Schedule of Works in Section 9.
- Supplied the idea of inviting readers to pitch a character, adapted from WEBTOON Canvas, as the project's own growth mechanism (Section 6, Section 12).
- Supplied McCloud's closure theory as the design reason behind the scroll reveal comic panel pattern actually built in Firmness (Section 8).

// SECTION 04

Business

The brief is clear that a Major Project website need not be commercial, but there must be a clearly defined set of aims and the resources of time and money to sustain it (University of Greenwich, 2025). KICKERSHOE's business case, presented at Crit 1 (21 January 2026, Final Concept: Business, Cultural Context and Commodity) and unchanged in substance through to Completion, is that it is non commercial and editorial by design. There is no cart, no shop, no advertising sold, and no paywall. The return it is built to generate is credibility, craft and an archive worth returning to, not revenue, in the module's own words, the alternate value the project will deliver in place of a revenue stream (University of Greenwich, 2025).

Resourcing

The resource cost is almost entirely the founder's own time: writing, illustration direction and hand built front end development, alongside a small stack of free tier or near free tools. These include Vercel hosting on its free tier with automatic deployment from GitHub, a single registered domain, Google Fonts, Web3Forms for the newsletter, and Microsoft Clarity and Vercel Speed Insights for analytics. None of these carries a meaningful running cost at the site's current scale. This is a deliberate choice rather than a constraint accepted reluctantly. Keeping the cost base close to zero is what makes a genuinely non commercial, no advertising, no tracking pixel promise sustainable for as long as the project continues, rather than only for as long as a single student's budget lasts. The site's own cookie notice puts this plainly: a few crumbs for anonymous performance stats and to remember this choice, no ad trackers, no resale (kickershoe.com).

SWOT analysis

	Helpful	Harmful
Internal	A genuinely different format. No direct competitor occupies the sneaker comic space (Section 3). Zero running cost keeps the non commercial promise believable in the long run. A hand built, framework free stack gives full control over performance and accessibility (Section 8).	Solo production. Writing, art direction and development all sit with one person, which limits output. A four issue archive is still small next to competitors' back catalogues, which limits how much organic search area it can cover. The illustration process, which uses AI assisted image generation as described in Section 13, still needs real time per issue to art direct and compose into finished panels.
External	An open invitation for readers to pitch a character (Section 6) could turn readers into contributors, the way WEBTOON Canvas does at far greater scale (Section 3). Cross posting to platforms such as Webtoon Canvas or Tapas, and to comic community social channels, is an	Large sneaker media companies (Section 3) dominate branded and non branded search terms and could copy a similar format if it proved popular. The project's own unofficial, unaffiliated framing, needed for legal safety and explained below, sets a permanent limit

	untapped distribution route (Section 10, Section 12). Sneaker culture's continued growth as a mainstream interest (Section 5) keeps the underlying audience growing.	on how directly it can reference real brands in its own marketing. Relying on free tier infrastructure such as Vercel and Web3Forms is a manageable but real platform risk.
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Trademark and the unofficial position

Because every issue's shoe design deliberately echoes a real, identifiable silhouette, such as a spring loaded high top, a mantis green football boot, or a gold and black F50 style boot, the business case depends on the same disclaimer discipline used generally by fan fiction and parody creators. The About page's Not Affiliated section states outright that any resemblance to real shoe silhouettes, brand names, or design lineage is homage, parody and speculation, and not affiliation, sponsorship or endorsement by any real company or person (kickershoe.com/about). This is treated here as a business critical decision rather than a legal detail. It is the only reason the project can engage with real design history at all without needing a licensing arrangement it has no route to obtaining.

// SECTION 05

Cultural Context

The module asks this report to place the project within the wider context of history and contemporary culture, so its existence can be explained rather than simply stated (University of Greenwich, 2025). KICKERSHOE sits inside two histories that are not often discussed together: the cultural history of the sneaker, and the more recent history of vertical, serialised digital comics. Its central creative bet is that the second is a good vehicle for telling the first.

Sneakers as a cultural object

Sneakers stopped being purely athletic equipment once hip hop and streetwear, from the 1980s onward, adopted them as markers of identity. This shift is documented at length in Elizabeth Semmelhack's *Out of the Box: The Rise of Sneaker Culture*, the companion volume to the Bata Shoe Museum's touring exhibition of the same name, which traces sneaker design from an 1860s spiked running shoe through to present day designer collaborations, as a continuous story of sports technology being absorbed into fashion and status (Semmelhack, 2015). Bobbito Garcia's *Where'd You Get Those?* gives a more personal, first hand version of the same shift, cataloguing nearly 400 models from New York's 1970 to 1987 golden years and arguing that a small, dedicated community of early sneaker buyers, rather than the manufacturers themselves, was what actually built Nike's and Adidas's cultural relevance (Garcia, 2003). Designer and musician collaborations, such as Kanye West with Adidas and Travis Scott with Nike, together with the rise of Instagram, TikTok and YouTube unboxing culture, have since turned sneaker collecting itself into a form of storytelling, not only a form of buying, which is exactly the ground the cognate outlets in Section 3 now compete over.

KICKERSHOE's position within that history is deliberately indirect rather than direct. It does not report on real releases, real collaborations or real resale prices, the way every cognate outlet in Section 3 does. Instead it treats the origin story impulse that already surrounds real sneaker culture (the apocryphal stories, the did you know facts about a shoe's design, the reverence that Garcia's book is itself built from) as raw material for invented fiction. The project's own materials describe this as culture over hype, craft over trends territory, distinct from celebrity led coverage such as GQ and from luxury leaning coverage such as *Coveteur*, and distinct even from the fan history tradition Garcia represents, since it does not claim its stories are true.

Webcomics as a publishing form

Choosing a comic, rather than an article, as the delivery format is itself a cultural decision. Scott McCloud's *Understanding Comics* reframed comics from a genre, associated mainly with superheroes and funny animals, into a medium defined by pictures and other images placed together in a deliberate sequence, capable of carrying any subject with the same seriousness as prose (McCloud, 1994). The clearest commercial proof of that argument is WEBTOON, whose vertical scroll format is now so common that the word webtoon is used generically for any comic published in that layout, and whose 2023 international revenue of 3.5 billion dollars shows that scroll native, mobile first comics are a mainstream reading habit rather than a niche one (TaleAtelier, 2026). KICKERSHOE borrows the scroll native reading pattern, panel by panel reveal keyed to scroll position, without adopting WEBTOON's

usual genres of romance, fantasy and slice of life, and applies it instead to product design history, a subject the format has not obviously been used for before.

Hype, resale culture, and why KICKERSHOE avoids both

No account of present day sneaker culture is complete without its resale economy. StockX and GOAT turned limited release sneakers into a tradeable asset class through the 2010s, and the release calendar journalism practised by every cognate outlet in Section 3 exists largely to feed that market's need for advance notice and hype. Garcia's own account of the 1970s and 1980s already shows early signs of this, in the status attached to owning a rare colourway before anyone else, but the scale and speed of it today is a distinctly social media era phenomenon (Semmelhack, 2015). KICKERSHOE's cultural position is defined as much by what it leaves out as by what it does. It names no release dates, no resale values and no cop or drop verdicts anywhere in its four issues, because a story about a mocked, injured mantis earning a boot through struggle is a different kind of object to a countdown timer for a restock. This is not a criticism of hype culture so much as a choice of a different, older register, closer to fable and folklore than to market journalism, which also happens to be a register a solo illustrator and writer can sustain without needing access to embargoed release information.

Where KICKERSHOE sits

Placed against both histories at once, KICKERSHOE reads as a small, personal experiment that combines two traditions. It takes sneaker culture's respect for design detail from writers such as Garcia and Semmelhack, and it takes comics' capacity for clear, emotionally readable, sequential storytelling from the tradition McCloud described and WEBTOON later made commercially successful, then puts the two together in a form that neither the sneaker media world nor the webcomics world currently occupies. Its unofficial, unaffiliated framing is also a small piece of cultural commentary in its own right. It treats the corporate origin stories that brands actually publish, usually a paragraph of marketing copy on a product page, as the least interesting version of a shoe's history, and stakes the whole project on the idea that an invented, carefully illustrated one is more memorable.

// SECTION 06

Commodity

Commodity, in the module's framework, concerns content, information architecture, accessibility and functionality from the user's point of view, and not visual design, which belongs to Delight (University of Greenwich, 2025). This section covers the personas defined at Crit 1 (21 January 2026) and carried through the project, two further personas added for this final report to broaden the picture, the information architecture as it was realised, and, in the interest of full honesty, the fact that the content format itself changed underneath those personas partway through the project.

Personas

Three personas were defined at Crit 1 and were never formally revised, on the view that a change of content format does not necessarily mean a change of audience. People who care about sneaker culture are, broadly, still the right people to write for even once the format is a comic rather than an article. Two further personas, Aanya and Tomas, are added below for this report. They were not part of the original crit material. They are included because the report was asked to widen the persona set and to say more about how the site's resources were built to meet what each type of reader is actually looking for.

Persona	Profile and goals	How KICKERSHOE serves them
Bil Sneaker collector, early 20s, culinary student	Sees sneakers as wearable art. Collects for design and story rather than resale value. Wants depth beyond a spec sheet.	The comic format gives Bil a designed artefact to sit with rather than a news item to skim. An issue is built to reward slow, attentive reading, the same way a collector already looks closely at a shoe. The site's field notes and lore sections give Bil something to return to after the main story.
Madavan Fashion and marketing enthusiast, early 20s, digital marketing student	Interested in the brand strategy and storytelling behind releases. Follows sneaker media mainly for the narrative, not only the product.	The About page's explanation of how the shared universe connects, including recurring rivals and hidden references to real athletes, gives Madavan the same kind of behind the scenes narrative structure this persona already follows cognate outlets for, but told as fiction instead of marketing.
Freya Creative professional, late 20s to 30s, illustrator or designer	Judges work mainly on craft and originality. A likely candidate to actually pitch a character rather than only read.	The shared universe, open submission model (Section 3, Section 12) gives Freya a route from reader to contributor that a normal editorial site has no real equivalent for. The published moodboard and colour system (Section 7) give a clear visual brief for anyone pitching new work.
Aanya International design student, mid 20s, studying content strategy or illustration	Reads the site partly as a case study, interested in how a small comic project handles content strategy, accessibility and SEO as much as the stories themselves. Likely to arrive through a shared	The README and design documentation kept in the project's own repository, together with the site's semantic markup and accessibility choices (Section 8), give Aanya a visible example of process, not only a finished product. This mirrors the author's own

	link or a search for sneaker origin stories rather than sneaker news.	position as an international student building a portfolio piece.
Tomas General reader, any age, arrives through a shared comic panel on social media	Not particularly invested in sneaker culture. Drawn in mainly by the artwork and the emotional pull of a single panel, then curious enough to read further.	The Open Graph preview built for every issue (Section 10) shows real panel art rather than a generic banner, so a shared link already looks like a piece of art before Tomas clicks. The newsletter is a low commitment way to stay in touch without needing any prior interest in sneakers.

What building for five personas actually changed

Adding Aanya and Tomas to the persona set was not only an exercise in filling out a table. It changed two real resourcing decisions late in the project. First, the README and the design specification files kept in the repository were written with more care than a purely internal working document usually needs, on the basis that a reader like Aanya might genuinely look at them. Second, the Open Graph preview work described in Section 10 was prioritised earlier than it might otherwise have been, specifically because a reader like Tomas will only ever see the site through a shared panel, and that first impression has to work without any existing interest in sneakers to rely on.

User journey: Bil, from first visit to newsletter sign up

Walking one persona through the realised architecture from start to finish helps to show how the pieces fit together. Bil arrives at kickershoe.com from a shared link to Issue 002, not from the homepage, which is the most common real entry point for a small, share driven site. The Open Graph preview described in Section 10 has already shown him the F50 style boot and the headline before he clicks, so he arrives with the right expectation rather than a cold homepage bounce. He reads the full ten panel issue at his own scroll pace, with the Intersection Observer reveal described in Section 8 pacing the story rather than an autoplay slideshow doing it for him. The lore case file at the foot of the issue, with its declassified hidden athlete reference, is what a design attentive collector like Bil is most likely to linger on, since it rewards the close, detail first reading his persona already describes. From there, the About link in the main navigation carries him to the About page, where the cast gallery lets him place Issue 002's goat against the mantis he has not yet read, and the newsletter form on the Connect section is the only conversion point offered. This is a deliberate choice, one action rather than three, so a first time reader is never asked to choose between competing calls to action.

This journey, discover a single issue through a shared link, read it fully, then subscribe, was tested informally against each persona during development by asking, for each proposed page, which persona it was mainly built for and what that persona would likely do next. The method borrows from the Empathy Mapping and Storyboarding techniques introduced in the programme's User Experience Design workshops, used here informally rather than as a separate documented exercise, in keeping with the brief's own advice to use whatever tools seem appropriate to the project (University of Greenwich, 2025).

Information architecture, as built

The realised architecture is deliberately shallow. The homepage (Origin) carries a hero, a four issue teaser slider and a latest drop label. From there a reader moves to an issue page, the panel by panel motion comic followed by a field notes lore case file, then to the About page (mission, cast, how the shared universe connects, the not affiliated disclaimer), and finally to Connect, a single newsletter form promising one email per chapter and no tracking pixels. This is close to, but simpler than, the architecture set at Crit 1: homepage, story pages, a filterable archive, then about and contact. The filterable archive, organised by era, designer and genre and planned for a weekly article model, was dropped once the content unit became a small, fixed set of full comic issues rather than a growing article library, since a filter interface has little value across only four items. The user journey narrowed accordingly, from the originally planned discover, engage and return, to a tighter discover, read and subscribe, which is a more honest match for what four issues can actually support.

The content format change, and what it did to Commodity

The single biggest Commodity level change across the project was not a page or a feature. It was the content unit itself, moving from a growing weekly article archive to a small, fixed set of illustrated comic issues. This was not disclosed as clearly at the time as the naming change was, and it is disclosed fully here because the brief specifically rewards being able to explain and justify decisions during project development rather than assuming a plan that was simply executed unchanged (University of Greenwich, 2025). The honest reason for the change is capacity. The Crit 1 plan for weekly story output, filterable by era, designer and cultural moment, assumed a production pace that the SWOT analysis in Section 4 had already flagged as a risk, since story production is time heavy. Over the implementation summer, a small number of fully illustrated, ten panel comic issues turned out to be a more realistic unit of finished work than a continuous stream of shorter articles would have been for one person to sustain to a professional standard.

The Commodity cost of that decision is real and is stated plainly. Four issues is a thin archive next to any cognate competitor. The filterable, era based browsing experience promised at Crit 1 no longer exists in any form. A first time visitor has less to explore than the original plan implied. The Commodity benefit, which this report judges to outweigh that cost for a project of this size, is that every one of the four issues that does exist is a complete, polished, accessible, SEO tagged piece of work, rather than one of a larger number of thinner ones. The invitation for readers to pitch a character (Section 3, Section 12) is the structural answer to the archive size weakness. It turns growing the archive into something the community can help with, rather than only a solo production bottleneck.

// SECTION 07

Delight

Delight covers the visual identity and brand: colour, type, imagery and interface style, judged against the target audience and genre rather than in the abstract (University of Greenwich, 2025).

KICKERSHOE's visual system was set at Crit 2 (25 February 2026, Brand Design) as a moodboard, and, unusually for this project, it is the one major element that survived the implementation summer essentially unchanged. The completion presentation's own claim that the moodboard held from the early brand work through to launch is supported by the live site's stylesheet, checked directly against the presented palette for this report.

Brand system

The look is a torn paper, halftone comic style laid over a near black ground, with one loud accent colour doing most of the interface's expressive work. The screenshots in this report (Figures 1 and 2) show the system in production use: a dark stage that recedes behind hand illustrated panel art, a single neon green accent carrying every interactive or live signal (the JS ON toggle, hover states, the OUT NOW label), and a bright purple kept almost entirely for the wordmark and a small number of emphasis words, such as SHOE in the About page's hero headline.

Token	Hex	Role
Background	#0A0F0A	Page ground, near black, so illustrated panel art carries the colour.
Primary	#39FF14	Neon green, every interactive or live signal: links, the motion toggle, OUT NOW labels, selection colour.
Secondary	#FF8A14	Warm orange, secondary emphasis and footer meta text.
Gold	#D4A23A	Reserved accent, used sparingly across issue art direction.
Purple	#DC00DC	The wordmark and single word headline emphasis, the brand's signature colour.

Typography follows the same rule of letting one accent do the work. Anton, a tall, heavy, condensed display face, is used for every headline, visible in Figures 1 and 2's oversized THE MANTIS ORIGIN and EVERY SHOE HAS A STORY treatments. JetBrains Mono is used for every meta label and eyebrow, such as ISSUE 001, A KICKERSHOE COMIC, and for interface text generally, and is borrowed directly for this report's own section eyebrows and captions as one of its few deliberate, restrained nods to the live site. Space Grotesk is used for body copy, chosen for legibility at the smaller sizes a lore case file or a caption needs. This report does not try to copy that system in full. A dark, neon on black academic report would be difficult to read and expensive to print. Instead it borrows the logic in a print safe form: a muted, darker green standing in for the neon primary in headings and rules, the same mono, display and body split, and a palette table above that uses the true site hex values, so the design intent is documented exactly even where the report itself uses softened versions of the same colours.

Imagery and illustration direction

Every character is illustrated in a painterly, slightly gritty style with visible brushwork and halftone texture, consistent across four issues produced over roughly three months. This consistency matters more for a shared universe than for a single story, since Issue 002's antagonist has to be recognisable when he reappears later as a collaborator. Comic panels use diagonal cut panel shapes rather than plain rectangles, a Firmness side implementation covered in Section 8, but a Delight side decision originally, which keeps the halftone and torn paper feel alive in the structure of the layout and not only in the artwork itself.

Where Delight changed

The one significant simplification on the Delight side was dropping an early ambition, discussed at the Firmness crit (Section 8), for a Three.js rendered 3D hero shoe with synchronised audio, in favour of the static, illustrated hero and motion comic format actually shipped. This is covered fully as a technical decision in Section 8, but is worth naming here too. It was, first of all, a decision to protect the illustration and writing budget, since a 3D centrepiece would have used time that instead went into producing four complete, polished comic issues. Judged purely on Delight, this was the right trade. A static, torn paper comic style, carried out consistently, reads as more finished than a partly built 3D showpiece would have.

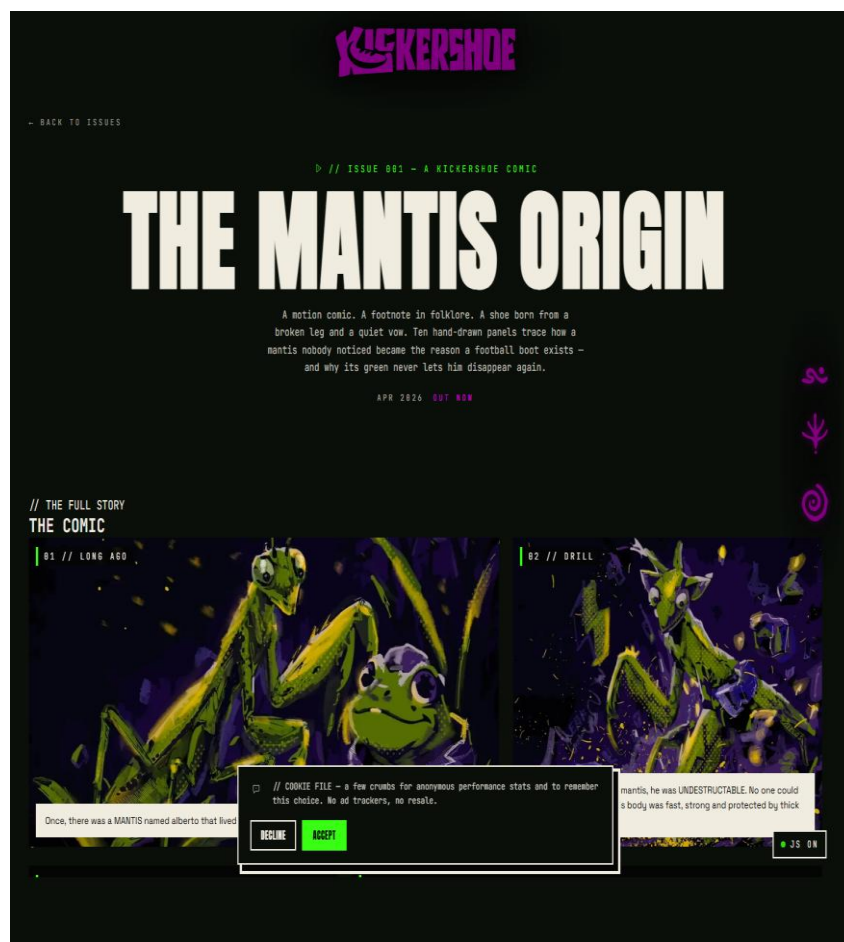


Figure 1. Issue 001, The Mantis Origin: display font headline, mono eyebrow label, and the diagonal cut comic panel grid (kickershoe.com/issue-001).

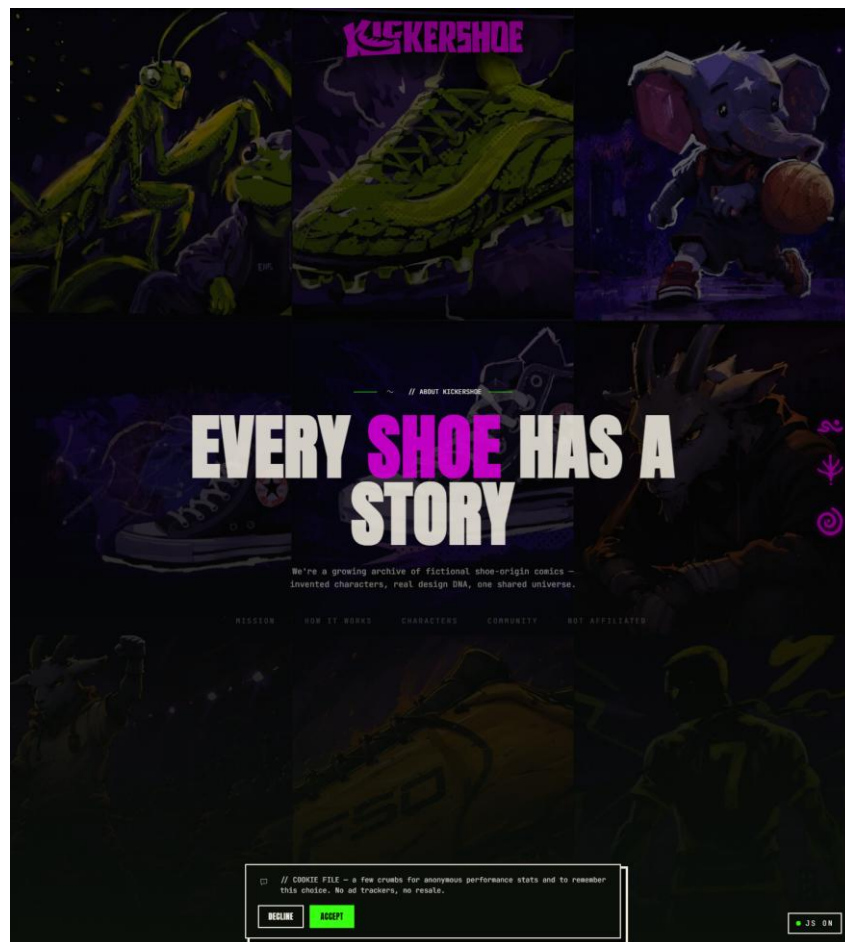


Figure 2. The About page hero: a nine tile comic panel mosaic behind the headline, with the purple wordmark and single word emphasis colour (kickershoe.com/about).

// SECTION 08

Firmness

Firmness covers the technical side of the project: hosting, front end and server side technology choices, version control, and CMS decisions, along with the reasoning behind each (University of Greenwich, 2025). This is the section where the gap between the Crit 3 technical plan and what was actually shipped is widest, and it is covered here in full, including what was kept, what was exceeded, and what was deliberately dropped.

What was pledged at Crit 3 (as Sick.Shoes, 1 April 2026)

The Crit 3 technical plan committed to the following. Semantic HTML5 with no div based layouts. Native CSS nesting and custom properties, mobile first, with no pre-processor. A strictly vanilla JavaScript approach using the Intersection Observer API for scroll triggered animation and the Web Audio or HTML audio element for music synchronised story pages. Git and GitHub with a main branch and feature branches. Netlify hosting on its free tier, chosen for its content delivery network, automatic deployment from GitHub, and built in form handling. The domain sick.shoes. A deliberately delayed decision on a content management system, static HTML at launch, with Contentful identified as the likely headless system once the archive passed roughly fifty articles.

What was actually built

- Static HTML5, CSS3 and vanilla JavaScript, with no build framework. This was kept, and taken further than pledged. The site's markup is fully semantic with no div element and no class attribute anywhere in the document, styled entirely by element type, structural relationships and attribute selectors (see the design notes kept in docs/design/specs/ in the project repository).
- Intersection Observer scroll animation. This was kept and used for exactly what it was pledged for: a panel by panel comic reveal, where each panel's image fades in, then its caption appears, then its words appear one at a time as the reader scrolls, a direct application of the McCloud based pacing argument set out in Section 5.
- An accessible motion on and off toggle, and a cookie consent notice, were added beyond the original pledge, once the scroll animation heavy format made a way to turn off motion an accessibility necessity rather than a nice extra.
- Full SEO implementation, including JSON-LD structured data for Organization and WebSite along with an ItemList of every issue on the homepage, ComicIssue and BreadcrumbList data on each issue page, Open Graph and Twitter Card previews, canonical tags, a sitemap and a robots file, was built out well beyond the Crit 3 plan's brief mention of social sharing meta tags.
- A WCAG based accessibility pass was run late in implementation, fixing a colour contrast failure and a set of errors flagged by the WAVE tool, and separately fixing a genuine regression where the mobile navigation's link text briefly lost its accessible name entirely (commit 31fa22a, 31 August 2026), caught and corrected before launch rather than left in production.

Where the plan changed, and why

Pledged (Crit 3)	Shipped	Reason for the change
Domain: sick.shoes	Domain: kickershoe.com	Follows the naming change explained in Section 2. The main reason was SEO, on the advice of tutors reviewing the project, since a plain, single word brand name is easier to search for and to rank.
Hosting: Netlify free tier	Hosting: Vercel, automatic deployment from GitHub on every push to the main branch	A platform switch made during implementation for an equivalent free tier content delivery network with a build step (npm run build into a dist folder) and built in Speed Insights analytics. This is a change of provider, not a change of principle.
Web Audio API: synchronised audio on each story page	Dropped entirely	Simplified out, along with the 3D hero below, to protect the writing and illustration budget once the content unit became four fully realised comic issues rather than a continuous story stream (Section 6, Section 7).
A Three.js rendered 3D hero shoe, discussed informally at the Firmness crit	A static illustrated hero and four issue teaser slider	Same reason as above. A 3D showpiece was judged to cost more build time than it would return, against a static motion comic format that could ship four complete issues in the same time.
CMS path: static for now, Contentful once the archive passes roughly fifty articles	Static HTML throughout. The WordPress or Contentful path was dropped for the current archive size.	At four issues, a headless content system adds real complexity for little practical benefit. This is revisited honestly in Section 12 as future work, once the archive genuinely earns it.
Forms and analytics: Netlify Forms, no analytics platform specified	Web3Forms for the newsletter. Vercel Speed Insights for Core Web Vitals. Microsoft Clarity for behavioural analytics. Google Search Console verification added.	Netlify specific tooling no longer applied once hosting moved to Vercel. The analytics stack was assembled piece by piece during the Analysis phase (Section 11) rather than specified in advance.

On the WordPress and page builder policy

The brief is explicit that WordPress page builders such as Elementor are not appropriate for this project, and that a bespoke, hand built theme is rewarded over an off the shelf one where both are carried out to a similar standard (University of Greenwich, 2025). KICKERSHOE never used WordPress or a page builder at any stage. The entire site, at every phase from Crit 3 onward, has been hand written HTML, CSS and JavaScript, with one genuine point covered honestly in Section 13: AI tools were used throughout to help draft and speed up that hand written work, which this report treats as a separate, clearly disclosed question from the page builder policy, and not a way of quietly meeting it through other means.

Version control and deployment

The project is tracked in a single GitHub repository (github.com/stalineapen652-ui/kickershoe-html), with 64 commits between the first commit on 3 June 2026 and the most recent on 4 September 2026. Feature branches were used for the two largest structural changes, the fully semantic HTML rewrite and the About page and SEO foundation addition, both merged into the main branch through a pull request (commit 582ed74, Rewrite site as fully semantic HTML, no div, class or id, together with a companion README addition). Every push to main triggers an automatic Vercel production deployment, so the commit history also works, in effect, as a deployment history. The log itself is a fairly detailed record of the project's real priorities in its final months: separate commits for adding each new issue, for the semantic rewrite, for converting all imagery to WebP and packaging the analytics bundle for performance, for the accessibility and WAVE error fixes, and, in the final week before this report, for a run of SEO work covering Search Console verification, Microsoft Clarity and an ItemList structured data pass, which lines up directly with the Analysis phase priorities set out in Section 11.

// SECTION 09

Prototype and Schedule of Works

The Prototype phase, presented at Crit 4 on 29 April 2026, required a working demonstration rich enough for tutors to understand the vision for the completed site, a summary of the three prior crits, and a schedule of works with an estimated launch date, presented as a Gantt chart (University of Greenwich, 2025). This section reconstructs that crit and the schedule it set, and reports honestly against it.

The journey, crit by crit

The crit dates and titles below follow the module's own published schedule (University of Greenwich MA Web Design and Content Planning, 2026), rather than the looser labels used in the author's own working slides at the time.

Crit	When	What it covered
Concept (informal, pre-crit)	Autumn 2025	Sick.Shoes proposed as a non commercial storytelling platform, no marketplace. The elevator pitch, USP and manifesto were set (Section 2), ahead of any dated crit.
Crit 1, Final Concept	21 January 2026	Business, Cultural Context and Commodity presented together. Three personas defined (Section 6).
Crit 2, Brand Design	25 February 2026	Delight presented: the moodboard, colour palette and typography that held through to launch (Section 7).
Crit 3, Technical Planning	1 April 2026	Firmness presented: the technical pledge set out in full (Section 8).
Crit 4, Prototype	29 April 2026	Renamed to Kickershoe for SEO reasons (Section 2). Domain secured. This schedule of works presented, targeting a launch by mid August.
Crit 5, Final presentation and submission	2 September 2026	Four full issues shipped, the site hardened for accessibility, tuned for mobile performance, made SEO ready, and deployed. This report.

Schedule of works (as presented at Crit 4, reported against actual delivery)

Task	Planned window	Actual	Outcome
Issue 001 build (Mantis)	Early June	3 to 4 June	On schedule
Brand asset conversion and performance pass	Mid June	5 August	Slipped by around 7 weeks
Semantic HTML rewrite, no div, class or id	Late June	19 August	Slipped by around 8 weeks, see Reflection, Section 12
Issues 002 to 004 build	July to early August	23 to 31 August	Compressed into the final fortnight

About page and SEO foundation	Early August	26 August	Close to plan
Accessibility and mobile performance hardening	Pre-launch buffer	30 to 31 August	Run as planned, but with less buffer than intended
SEO hardening (Search Console, Clarity, schema)	Post launch	2 to 4 September	On schedule
Site launch (kickershoe.com live)	Mid August 2026	Live from early June, hardened through early September	Effectively met, see note below

Gantt view: actual delivery, reconstructed from the commit history

The Crit 4 presentation deck itself is not kept as an editable Gantt file, so rather than redraw the plan from memory, the chart below is built the more reliable way, directly from the project's own git commit timestamps (Section 8), and shows when each task band was actually active, month by month, across the implementation window.

Task	Jun	Jul	Aug (early)	Aug (late)	Sep
Issue 001 build					
Brand assets and performance pass					
Semantic HTML rewrite					
Issues 002 to 004 build					
About page and SEO foundation					
Accessibility and mobile hardening					
SEO hardening and analytics					

The visual pattern makes the point of the Section 12 reflection plainer than the table above can in words. June and July are nearly empty next to the density of shaded cells from mid August onward, where five separate task bands are compressed into roughly a three week window. A schedule this back loaded worked only because the underlying build was small enough, four issues and one shared stylesheet, for one person to push through in a concentrated sprint. It is not a pattern this report recommends repeating at a larger scale, and Section 12 names the specific re-sequencing that would fix it.

Two things are worth being precise about in the schedule table above. First, the site was technically live and deployed from the very first commit in early June, since Vercel's automatic deployment meant there was never a real gap between built and launched in the usual sense. Launch is better read here as feature complete and hardened, which happened in the first days of September, roughly two to three

weeks after the mid August target set at Crit 4. Second, the single largest delay, the semantic HTML rewrite, originally planned for late June and not finished until 19 August, is named honestly here rather than smoothed over, and is discussed fully as a scheduling lesson in Section 12's reflection, since it is the clearest single explanation for why the four comic issues themselves were compressed into the final fortnight of August rather than spread evenly across the summer as planned.

// SECTION 10

Implementation

The Implementation report is asked to describe how the previous phases came together into a coherent website, to detail any problems and any changes from the plan, and to describe the SEO and social or promotional strategy, whether already carried out or still planned (University of Greenwich, 2025). Sections 8 and 9 have already covered the technical changes and the schedule. This section focuses on how the four issues themselves came together, the problems that came up during the process, and the promotional strategy the site now carries.

How the site came together

The build proceeded issue by issue rather than page by page. Issue 001, The Mantis Origin, was built first, in early June, at first as a section of the homepage before being split out into its own page on 4 August once its length made a shared homepage difficult to manage, a structural decision made in response to real content rather than planned in advance. Issues 002 and 003 followed in mid to late August, with their numbering swapped partway through once the finished stories made it clear the Goat's storyline was the stronger opening for the second slot. Issue 004, The Goldfish Memory, shipped last, on 31 August, alongside a full site wide content and layout pass. The About page and the site's SEO foundation, including the sitemap, canonical tags, structured data and Open Graph previews, were added together on 26 August, once there was a stable four issue library worth making discoverable.

Problems encountered

- Caption clipping and layout bugs. Several early comic panel captions clipped or overlapped during their scroll reveal animation, fixed in a dedicated content and SEO pass that also improved caption typography (commit 46636d8). This was a direct result of writing captions of varying length against a fixed height panel design, caught through the same kind of careful review this report's own screenshots surface again in Section 7.
- A cumulative layout shift issue traced to the web font swap on page load, fixed the same day it was found (commit 1ae129e) by adjusting the fallback font so the swap from a system font to Anton and Space Grotesk does not visibly move the page, directly relevant to the Core Web Vitals audit in Section 11.
- A genuine accessibility regression, where the mobile navigation links lost their accessible name entirely under certain conditions, was caught and fixed on 31 August (commit 31fa22a), only days before the Completion crit, which is part of the reason the accessibility pass was scheduled as late as it was rather than treated as a one off early task.
- The semantic HTML rewrite, which removed every div, class and id from the markup, landed roughly eight weeks later than scheduled (Section 9), which compressed the remaining issue build work into a shorter window than planned and is the project's clearest single implementation phase lesson, expanded further in Section 12.

SEO strategy

The SEO approach has three layers, all visible in the repository's final week of commits. First, on page fundamentals: a unique title and description per page, canonical tags, and keyword rich internal link text. The generic read issue links across the homepage and About page carry accessible, keyword specific label text, for example describing Issue 002 by name and by the boot it explains, so that both screen readers and search engines get real context instead of a bare issue number. Second, structured data: JSON-LD Organization and WebSite schema, plus an ItemList of all four issues on the homepage, ComicIssue and BreadcrumbList schema on each issue page, and AboutPage schema on the About page, meant to give search engines an explicit, machine readable map of the site's content rather than leaving them to guess at it. Third, off site foundations: a sitemap and robots file at the site root, Google Search Console site verification, added 2 September 2026, and Open Graph and Twitter Card previews built around real panel art rather than a generic banner, so that a shared comic panel appears as an actual image card on social platforms rather than a blank link preview.

Promotional and social strategy

The realistic promotional strategy for a four issue, zero budget project is narrow, and deliberately so. A single newsletter capture, one email per chapter with no filler and no tracking pixels (kickershoe.com), is the main way readers are kept in touch, rather than a broad social media push the current amount of content could not really sustain. The project's own README is candid that off site distribution is not automated by anything in the repository and is left to whoever runs the site to carry out, naming this as the highest leverage remaining step for competing against larger sneaker media sites on non branded search terms. It names submitting the sitemap to Search Console, mirroring issues to a platform such as Webtoon Canvas or Tapas, and cross posting panels, as the next concrete steps, carried forward into Section 12's future plans rather than claimed as already done.

// SECTION 11

Analysis

The Analysis phase asks for the site's performance to be measured using server logs, PageSpeed Insights, Google Analytics, and accessibility and SEO checkers, and for an honest judgement of whether the results meet the project's original goals (University of Greenwich, 2025). This report is direct about a limit on that ambition. Kickershoe.com was only hardened for accessibility and performance, and had its analytics instrumentation completed, in the final days of August and first days of September 2026, essentially the same week this report was written, so there is not yet a meaningful window of real user traffic to analyse. Rather than invent numbers the site does not yet have, this section reports what is actually true right now: what instrumentation is in place, and a first hand structural and accessibility audit carried out directly on the live site for this report.

Instrumentation in place

- Vercel Speed Insights, loaded on every page behind cookie consent, collects real user Core Web Vitals: Largest Contentful Paint (perceived load speed, target under 2.5 seconds), Interaction to Next Paint (responsiveness, target under 200 milliseconds), and Cumulative Layout Shift (visual stability, target under 0.1), assessed at the 75th percentile of real visits (web.dev, 2026).
- Microsoft Clarity, added on 2 September 2026, provides session recordings and heatmaps, giving qualitative behavioural data once traffic arrives, separate from the quantitative Core Web Vitals feed above.
- Google Search Console site ownership was verified on 2 September 2026, which is the first step needed before indexing status, search impressions and non branded query performance can be tracked once Google has crawled the site.
- A site wide cookie consent notice gates all of the above behind an explicit accept or decline choice, in the site's own words a few crumbs for anonymous performance stats, no ad trackers, no resale, consistent with the non commercial Business case in Section 4.

Because all three tools were switched on within the same week this report was written, there is honestly no traffic history yet worth quoting a figure from. A Search Console graph that is a week old is evidence only that verification worked, not evidence of readership. The goal for the next reporting cycle, discussed further in Section 12, is a first real reading of non branded search impressions and Core Web Vitals field data once a few weeks of genuine visits have built up.

First hand structural and accessibility audit

In place of an invented performance score, this section is based on a direct audit of the live site carried out for this report. The homepage, an issue page and the About page were loaded and inspected directly, using accessibility tree reads, network request inspection and manual navigation, rather than quoted from a dashboard. The findings were as follows.

- Every image request observed on first load returned WebP, consistent with the site's commits converting images to that format and maximising mobile performance (commits 562ed83 and ef0c8f0), and no console errors were logged on any of the three pages tested.

- Heading structure and semantic landmarks are present and sensible on every page tested, with a single heading level one per page, a properly labelled navigation region, and header, main and footer landmarks, consistent with the project's own rule of no div, no class and no id except as an anchor target (see Section 8 and the repository README).
- Decorative icon graphics across the site are correctly hidden from assistive technology, while meaningful images, such as character portraits and the shoe reveal images, carry specific, descriptive alternative text rather than a filename or a generic label, which is the correct pattern for telling decorative and informative images apart (W3C, 2023).
- One caption legibility issue was seen during this audit's own static capture of an issue page's scroll reveal panels, where Figure 1 shows two captions' text overlapping mid transition. This is most likely a timing artefact of capturing the panel reveal animation partway through with motion switched on, exactly the kind of thing the site's own motion on and off toggle exists to let a reader avoid, rather than a permanent layout fault. It is flagged here rather than quietly cropped out of the figure, and is worth a deliberate re-check with motion turned off before the next content update.

What counting as on target will mean next cycle

Vercel's own deployment dashboard already provides basic server log style data, including request counts, response codes and cache hit rates per deployment, without needing a separate logging service, and this was checked as part of the audit above. It currently shows only the low volume pattern of pre launch testing traffic, which is expected and is not reported here as a finding in its own right. The threshold this report sets for the next Analysis cycle, judged against the goals set out in Sections 2 and 4, has three parts. First, Search Console should show the site indexed and returning impressions for the keyword rich link text and structured data described in Section 10, rather than the current, not yet indexed state. Second, Speed Insights field data should confirm the good Core Web Vitals thresholds that the manual audit above could only estimate from a single session inspection. Third, the newsletter should record its first subscribers, which would be the first real evidence that the discover, read and subscribe journey designed in Section 6 actually works for genuine, unprompted readers rather than only in the walkthrough written for this report.

Set against the module's own list of judging qualities, including user experience, accessibility, SEO implementation, site performance, and the clarity, logic and structure of coding and standards compliance (University of Greenwich, 2025), the honest self assessment is as follows. The project is strong on coding structure, semantics and SEO implementation (Section 8, Section 10), reasonable on accessibility, with one known regression caught and fixed before launch and one minor animation timing issue still to verify, and simply too early to judge fairly on real world performance or traffic, since the instrumentation needed to measure either has only been live for days rather than weeks.

// SECTION 12

Completion: Reflection, Conclusion and Future Plans

What held up

- The moodboard and design system set at the Delight crit in February 2026, unchanged all the way through to launch (Section 7), and the part of the project that most closely matches its original plan.
- The story first, non commercial premise set at Crit 1, no cart, no shop, no advertising trackers, carried through to the live cookie consent copy in spirit if not word for word (Section 4).
- The domain and the broad launch estimate set at the Prototype crit in April 2026, met within a few weeks (Section 9).
- The Firmness pledge to build hand coded, semantic, framework free HTML, CSS and JavaScript, not only kept but exceeded, ending with a no div, no class markup discipline well beyond what was originally promised (Section 8).

What I would do differently

Three things, stated plainly rather than diplomatically. First, the semantic HTML rewrite should have started in June, not landed on 19 August. Scheduling it as a mid project task rather than an early one meant it competed directly with issue production time in the final six weeks, and it is the single clearest cause of the schedule compression documented in Section 9. Second, lore and story outlines should have been written well ahead of the build, rather than developed alongside it issue by issue. Writing the narrative and building the page it lives on in the same sitting, repeatedly, produced the kind of caption length and layout surprises documented in Section 10's list of problems. Third, the accessibility and mobile performance pass should have been run in stages across the summer rather than as a single push in the final week of August. It caught a real, launch blocking regression, discussed in Section 10, with very little buffer left to fix it, which is more risk than a project should carry this close to a deadline by choice.

What is next

- More issues, on a schedule that actually takes on board the lessons from Section 6 and Section 9, meaning lore written well ahead of build, and the invitation for readers to pitch a character, already live on the About page, treated as the project's main growth mechanism rather than a background feature.
- Submitting the sitemap to Search Console, since verification is already done and submission is the next concrete step, and pursuing the off site distribution the README already names as the highest leverage remaining step: a mirror on Webtoon Canvas or Tapas, and deliberate cross posting of panels to both comic and sneaker communities.
- A first genuine Analysis reading once Core Web Vitals field data and Search Console impressions have a few weeks of real traffic behind them, rather than the necessarily provisional, instrumentation only account given in Section 11.

- Revisiting a content management system once the archive genuinely earns it. The Contentful plan discussed at the Firmness crit was correctly shelved at four issues, not abandoned as a principle, and should be reconsidered once hand editing HTML for each new issue becomes the actual bottleneck rather than writing and illustration.

Conclusion

Judged against its own original brief, KICKERSHOE is a qualified but genuine success. The non commercial business case, the cultural positioning, the visual identity and the technical discipline set out across Crits 1 to 3 all survived to launch essentially intact, which is not a small thing over a twelve month, largely solo project. The one place the project did not simply carry out its original plan unchanged is also the place it is most important to be honest about, in a final report explicitly designed to reward that honesty. The content format itself moved from a real world magazine style platform to a fictional comic universe, a change of subject and form far larger than the naming changes that were talked through openly at every stage. That change is defended here on its own merits rather than apologised for. The Research (Section 3) and Cultural Context (Section 5) sections show that it filled a genuine, previously unoccupied gap between sneaker media and webcomics, and the finished site, at four issues, is a more complete and more accessible piece of work than a partly built magazine style platform covering the same ground would likely have been.

Where the project falls short of its own ambitions is in scale and proof, not in craft. Four issues is a thin archive next to any competitor named in Section 3. The schedule slipped by roughly two months against the Prototype crit's own estimate (Section 9). Most importantly, the site has not yet existed long enough to show whether real readers respond to it the way the Concept and Cultural Context sections argue they should. The instrumentation now in place (Section 11) exists specifically to answer that question honestly in the next reporting cycle, rather than to let this report answer it on the project's behalf before the evidence exists. On balance, the project succeeded at what a Major Project of this kind is actually meant to prove, that its author can conceptualise, research, design, build, document and honestly evaluate an independent piece of professional standard work, and did so by being willing to change the plan, openly, when the plan stopped being the right one.

// SECTION 13

AI Assistance and Tools Declaration

AI tools were used throughout this project as a supporting aid to speed up creative and technical decisions, not to replace them. This is the same declaration carried consistently from the Prototype stage onward, restated here in full rather than assumed.

Category	Tools and how they were used
Writing and development	Claude and Claude Code (Anthropic), used for project planning, research support and a majority share of the final hand edited, hand reviewed codebase. ChatGPT (OpenAI), used for research and ideation support and early drafting.
Design and prototyping	Figma and Lovable, used for early user interface design exploration and rapid prototyping ahead of the hand built implementation described in Section 8.
Images	Adobe Firefly and ChatGPT's image generator, used for comic panel and hero illustration, art directed and composed into the finished panels by the author.

This is disclosed on the same basis the module rewards elsewhere, that a decision explained and justified is worth more than a decision left hidden (University of Greenwich, 2025). Where AI assistance produced a first draft of code or of research notes, it was reviewed, edited and, in the case of the codebase, hand corrected against the project's own semantic HTML and accessibility standards (Section 8) before being treated as finished work. The analysis, argument, editorial decisions and final wording of this written report are the author's own.

// SECTION 14

References

Harvard, parenthetical, style, as required by the brief for print publications, and extended consistently to web and podcast sources (University of Greenwich, 2025).

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